

AUTISM SPECTRUM PARENTING TOOLKIT

Visual Schedules, Social Stories, Sensory Diet & IEP Prep

By Daniel Tesfamariam

UNDERSTANDING YOUR AUTISTIC CHILD

Autism is a neurological DIFFERENCE, not a deficiency.

Your child experiences the world more intensely - sounds louder, lights brighter, textures sharper, social rules more confusing.

KEY PRINCIPLES:

- Presume competence - they understand more than they can express
- Behavior IS communication - look for the unmet need
- Accommodate first, then teach - reduce barriers before adding demands
- Special interests are STRENGTHS - use them to teach other skills
- Meltdowns are NOT tantrums - they are nervous system overload

VISUAL SCHEDULE TEMPLATES

Visual schedules reduce anxiety by making the day predictable.

MORNING:

1. ☐ Wake up
2. ☐ Toilet
3. ☐ Get dressed (see outfit card)
4. ☐ Eat breakfast (see menu card)
5. ☐ Brush teeth
6. ☐ Get backpack
7. ☐ Go to school/car

AFTER SCHOOL:

1. ☐ Arrive home
2. ☐ Snack
3. ☐ Calm time (30 min)
4. ☐ Homework/therapy
5. ☐ Free time/special interest
6. ☐ Dinner
7. ☐ Bath
8. ☐ Bedtime routine

TIP: Use pictures/icons for non-readers. Velcro strips let child move items from 'to do' to 'done' for satisfaction.

SOCIAL STORIES TEMPLATE

Social stories explain situations in a clear, literal way:

Template structure:

1. SITUATION: Where/when does this happen?
2. PERSPECTIVE: How do others feel/think in this situation?
3. DIRECTIVE: What can I do?
4. AFFIRMATIVE: I will try my best. That's okay.

Example: Going to the Doctor

Sometimes I need to go to the doctor. (Situation)

The doctor wants to help me stay healthy. (Perspective)

I can bring my headphones and a comfort item. (Directive)

It might feel uncomfortable but it will be over soon. (Affirmative)

Write your own:

Situation: _____

Perspective: _____

Directive: _____

Affirmative: _____

SENSORY DIET PLANNER

A sensory diet provides regular sensory input throughout the day to keep your child regulated. Work with an OT to customize.

CALMING (when overstimulated):

- Deep pressure (weighted blanket, tight hugs, compression vest)
- Dim lights / reduce noise
- Slow rhythmic movement (rocking, swinging)
- Chewing (chewy tube, crunchy snacks)
- Warm bath or shower

ALERTING (when under-responsive):

- Cold water or ice
- Fast movement (jumping, spinning, running)
- Bright lights or music
- Sour or spicy flavors
- Vibration (vibrating toothbrush, massager)

ORGANIZING (for focus):

- Heavy work (carrying books, pushing cart, digging)
- Oral motor (drinking through straw, blowing bubbles)
- Fidget tools (putty, tangle, stress ball)
- Proprioceptive input (wall push-ups, bear walks)

SENSORY PROFILE WORKSHEET

Document your child's sensory preferences:

SOUND:

Bothered by: _____

Seeks/enjoys: _____

Accommodations: _____

TOUCH:

Bothered by: _____

Seeks/enjoys: _____

Accommodations: _____

SIGHT:

Bothered by: _____

Seeks/enjoys: _____

Accommodations: _____

TASTE/SMELL:

Bothered by: _____

Seeks/enjoys: _____

Accommodations: _____

MOVEMENT:

Bothered by: _____

Seeks/enjoys: _____

Accommodations: _____

IEP PREPARATION GUIDE

Know your rights. Come prepared. Bring this to meetings.

Child's name: _____ Grade: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Diagnosis: _____ Date of diagnosis: ____/____/____

STRENGTHS (lead with these!):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

AREAS OF NEED:

Academic: _____

Social: _____

Communication: _____

Behavioral: _____

Sensory: _____

ACCOMMODATIONS REQUESTING:

- ☐ Visual schedule in classroom
- ☐ Sensory breaks (frequency: _____)
- ☐ Noise-canceling headphones allowed
- ☐ Advance notice of schedule changes
- ☐ Social skills instruction
- ☐ Speech/language therapy
- ☐ Occupational therapy
- ☐ Aide/paraprofessional support
- ☐ Modified homework expectations
- ☐ Testing in quiet separate room
- ☐ Extended time on assignments
- ☐ Communication device/AAC access

MELTDOWN vs TANTRUM (Know the Difference)

TANTRUM (goal-directed):

- Child wants something specific
- Watches for your reaction
- Stops when they get what they want (or realize they won't)
- Can be redirected

MELTDOWN (nervous system overload):

- Caused by sensory/emotional overwhelm
- NOT within the child's control
- Cannot be reasoned with during it
- Needs safety and time to pass

DURING A MELTDOWN:

1. Ensure safety (move dangerous objects, create space)
2. Reduce sensory input (lights down, people back, quiet voice)
3. Don't talk too much (processing is overloaded)
4. Offer comfort items (blanket, headphones, chewy)
5. Wait. Be calm. Be present. It WILL pass.
6. After: reconnect, don't lecture. 'That was hard. I'm here.'

COMMUNICATION SUPPORT

If your child is verbal but struggles:

- Give processing time (wait 10+ seconds after asking)
- Use visual supports alongside verbal instructions
- One instruction at a time (not multi-step)
- Be literal (avoid sarcasm, idioms, implied meaning)

If your child is non-speaking or limited verbal:

- AAC (communication device) is NOT a last resort - offer early
- Honor ALL forms of communication (gesture, picture, behavior)
- Don't withhold AAC to 'encourage' speech
- Model AAC use yourself

Communication tools we use: _____

SLP (speech therapist): _____

OT (occupational therapist): _____

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